

CONFUCIUS



TWO THOUSAND YEARS AGO, China was in a state of turmoil and warfare. Strong imperial government had collapsed, and civil order had broken down. One man learned the lessons of this disorder. Confucius devised a moral code based on respect, kindness, and the strength of the family. He believed people could be taught to behave themselves as members of a well-ordered community. This vision, although based on a traditional view of Chinese society, is still influential in China today.

Confucius' teaching

Confucius learned to develop his new moral outlook from his experience in government. He taught that a good ruler should set an example by dealing fairly with his subjects, using force only as a last resort. In return, subjects had a duty to respect and obey their ruler.

Ancestor worship

In all his teachings, Confucius encouraged ancestor worship because it strengthened family ties. As a result, the Chinese people came to see themselves as part of a great national family that included not only living people but also the dead and those people who were still to be born. Many of the traditional Chinese gods and goddesses were believed to be ancestors who once lived as ordinary people in China and who, after their death, could influence everyday life.

Chün-tzu

According to the writings of Confucius, the ideal gentleman, or Chün-tzu, was a person who was compassionate, self-controlled, respectful of superiors, and concerned for the welfare of others. As a result, he was against slavery and human or animal sacrifices. Under the influence of Confucius it became common to bury pottery figures in tombs, rather than living animals or slaves.

Bronze tomb model of a rhinoceros



Traditional goddess, Kuan Yin

Zhou dynasty

Between 1027–256 BC, most of northern China was ruled by the Zhou dynasty. The early Zhou emperors ruled well, but later, as a result of pressure from powerful local lords, China split into a number of warring states. Confucius looked on the early years of the Zhou as a golden age of social harmony.



Handle in the form of mythical beast

Ritual vessel, Zhou period

Early life

Confucius was born in Lu province in northeast China in about 551 BC. His name was Kong Qiu. His father died when he was three, leaving his mother to bring him up. He became known as K'ung Fu-tse, or "great master kong". In the West he was called Confucius, the Latin form of this title.



Political career

For some years, Confucius worked as an adviser to the Duke of Lu and other local rulers. He attempted to promote good government by advising respect for the existing social order and fostering political stability. But his severe lifestyle and strict views were not popular, and Confucius eventually left Lu province.

Analects

Most of what we know about the teachings of Confucius can be found in a book of his sayings, the *Lun Yü*, or Analects. These sayings were collected by the followers of Confucius after his death. Confucius is also said to have compiled or edited five classic books known as the *Wu Ching*. The most famous of these is the *I Ching*, or Book of Changes. The *I Ching* provides a method of revealing the future through the use of 64 patterns of broken and unbroken lines.

Chinese characters written by a later follower of Confucius



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1027 BC Zhou dynasty takes control of northern China.

c.551 BC Confucius born in Lu.

532 BC Confucius marries.

531 BC Confucius' son born.

517 BC Confucius goes into exile for the first time.

501–496 BC Holds important post in Lu province.

483 BC Returns to Lu province after many years of wandering.

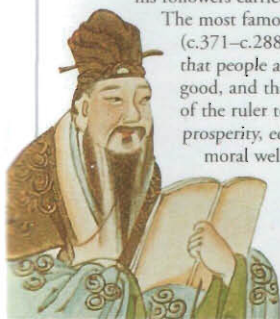
c.481–221 BC China splits into seven warring states.

c.479 BC Death of Confucius.

Mencius

After Confucius' death, a number of his followers carried on his work.

The most famous was Mencius (c.371–c.288). He believed that people are basically good, and that it is the duty of the ruler to ensure the prosperity, education, and moral well-being of his subjects. His pupils wrote down his thoughts and sayings in *The Book of Mencius*.



Impact

Although Confucius did not found a religion, his teachings are still influential throughout the world, especially in China, where the traditional values of the family are still based heavily on his views. The moral code taught by Confucius fits well with such established religions as Buddhism, Taoism, and Shinto, while his writings and classic texts are still widely studied in the West.



Chinese family, 19th century

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